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# *Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother!* by Ali Shariati

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**ABSTRACT**
Ali Shariati's travelogue *Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother* is widely regarded as one of his most distinctive works. In this brief yet profound critical-creative piece, Shariati (1933–1977), a leading Iranian anti-colonial thinker, returns to his lifelong concern: the question of liberation. For him, liberation – existential at its core and only then political – is mostly fully realized through literature, where form and content merge to express the inexpressible: to give voice to ideas, emotions, and critiques that dominant discourses suppress, or for which, as yet, no language exists. This conception of the literary, as a dynamic interplay between form and content, is exemplified in "Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother". Here, Shariati revives the epistolary genre, rooted in Persian literary history, to confront the sociopolitical challenges of his time while also opening a space for readers to reconsider the functions of the literary in the present world.

**KEYWORDS**
Ali Shariati; epistolary form; form–content dialectic; Islamic liberation theology; Persian literature; travelogue

## Translator's introduction

A couple of months before the 1979 Islamic Revolution in Iran, in an essay titled "What Are the Iranians Dreaming [*Revent*] About?", Michel Foucault (2005) mentions a figure whose invisible presence "haunts all political and religious life in Iran" (207). This enigmatic figure is Ali Shariati (1933–1977), the leading 20th-century Iranian revolutionary intellectual, anti-colonial thinker, Islamic philosopher, liberation theologist, and literary writer. Shariati is generally known for his significant role in the formation of the 1979 Islamic Revolution, a historic event that led to the overthrow of the Pahlavi dynasty, the last imperial monarchy of Iran (1925–1979), and the establishment of an Islamic Republic under Ayatollah Khomeini's leadership. His influence on the formation of the Revolution and its aftermath was so profound that, alongside Ayatollah Khomeini, he is widely regarded as one of its most pivotal architects. While Khomeini, as an Ayatollah, employed his spiritual authority derived from Islamic tradition to lead the people and urge them to rise up and act against the Pahlavi dynasty through his fatwas,[1] Shariati took a different approach. Through his public lectures and writings, he sought to nurture an alternative-revolutionary consciousness. His primary focus was on inspiring individuals – particularly the younger generation – and intellectually stimulating them to rise up,

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undergo self-transformation, and accordingly reshape the world around them, stressing that true revolution requires both personal-existential and societal-political liberation.

In his works, Ali Shariati develops a deeply humanistic theo-philosophy that revolves around the idea of liberation – both existential and political. This liberation philosophy is rooted in the Persian Islamic mystical tradition, which places particular emphasis on the question of existential liberation. However, Shariati rereads and appropriates this tradition within the revolutionary context of his time, infusing it with a radical political dimension to address contemporary challenges. At the heart of his philosophical vision lies the belief that the entire world is a prison, with everything around us designed to perpetuate a state of enslavement. Yet, for those who seek true emancipation, these very tools of oppression can – and must – be reimagined, translated, and transformed into instruments of liberation, much like Scheherazade in *The One Thousand and One Nights*, who turns the act of storytelling into a tool for liberating herself from the clutches of a tyrannical king. In his works, Shariati undertakes this liberatory project by offering a deconstructive reading of every method, approach, or idea surrounding him. Be it history, religion, sociology, or literature, all are stripped of their established historical contexts and reimagined with bold, future-oriented emancipatory functions. Through this profoundly creative and critical effort, Shariati emerges as not only a philosopher of literature, history, and religion (and, within the Iranian context, as an Islamic reformist) but also a revolutionary in the ideal sense, fostering solidarity among people and reframing revolution as the ultimate existential-political imperative – a means of actualizing oneself as a human being.

*Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother!* (*Ari Inchenin Bood Baradar* آری اینچنین بود برادر) – also known as "Shariati's Travelogue on Egypt" – is widely considered one of Ali Shariati's most distinctive works. Originally delivered as a lecture on Aban 18, 1350 SH (i.e. Sun Hirj; this Persian calendar date corresponds to November 9 in the Gregorian calendar) at Hosseinieh Ershad – a newly founded religious and cultural centre for lectures and discussions on Islamic thought, history, and culture – and later revised and published both as a stand-alone piece and in his collected works, it aligns seamlessly with the liberatory philosophy outlined above. At first glance, as a travelogue it appears to be a simple recounting of a memory of Shariati's recent trip to Egypt. However, beneath this surface narrative lies a profound exposition, not merely about visiting Egypt, but about embarking on a journey through 5000 years of history in the search for the self and his true family – a kinship defined not by blood or familial ties but by "existential sameness". This is a theme Shariati develops further in his magnum opus, *Kavir* (The desert), where he uses this term to describe the shared mode of being and thought that can connect lives separated by centuries. In this process, by situating himself within history, Shariati achieves the dual goals – one existential and the other political – of overcoming the loneliness and alienation of modern life, and criticizing the current repressive structures of power. This transformative journey, aimed at existential and political liberation, is deeply poetic and made possible through Shariati's use of the epistolary form, a well-established literary genre in the history of Persian literature. It is through writing in the form of a letter that the deconstructive-emancipatory reading of both history (as a discipline and a force) and literature (as an institution) becomes possible.

As a literary genre, the epistolary form was initially developed by the 11th-century Persian philosopher and mystic Ayn al-Qudat Hamedani, whom Shariati, in *Kavir*, refers to as his brother, and later adopted by others.[2] Ayn al-Qudat employed letter writing as a deeply personal, dialogical, and subversive mode of expression, guided by imagination and intentionally positioned as an alternative to logocentric, formal, and collective productions such as "'books' (*al-kitab*) and 'treatise' (*al-risala*) as the dominant metaphysical forms of 'Truth-Telling'" (Dabashi 2016, 375). Using the epistolary form, he sought to deconstruct archival-centred methods of studying juridical Islam, which dominated the intellectual and administrative discourse of his time, aiming to objectively express truth (Dabashi 2016, 356–366). By reconsidering the role of Arabic as the official language of the Islamic world – shaped by the constraints of a vast historical and juridical archive that dismissed new and alternative narratives as heretical – Ayn al-Qudat decided to write his letters in Persian. As a peripheral language unencumbered by such rigid archival traditions (*sunnat naqli*), Persian offered him a greater potential to create a more open space for personal and deconstructive narratives of Islam[3] – a space to express the inexpressible. For Ayn al-Qudat, therefore, the epistolary form became a tool of resistance against the dominance of archival and historical constraints, and a medium for deconstructing and transcending the rigid frameworks of official juridical or religious orthodoxy.

By embracing the epistolary form, and appropriating it in and for a sociopolitical context, Shariati consciously situates himself within the rich history of Persian literature, drawing on its capacity for introspection, creativity, and subversion. This deliberate choice allows him to transcend the limitations of conventional historiographical methods, which he saw as amplifying the voices of the powerful while silencing those of the marginalized and subaltern, whose lives remain largely undocumented. It also enables him to reclaim "the literary" as a space for engaging with the lingering traces of those lives and weaving a deconstructive narrative that opens up possibilities for reimagining historical and social realities excluded from dominant narratives. In this literary space, the personal and the political converge, providing a platform to articulate the inexpressible while critiquing power, history, and erasure. Thus, for Shariati, this reclamation is not merely an aesthetic choice but a political one: a deliberate act of resistance against the regimes of power and knowledge, firmly rooted in and attuned to the present moment. It seeks to reclaim erased histories and present an alternative framework for understanding the past – one that is more inclusive, just, and profoundly humane.

## Note on translation

Although Shariati's works have lost some popularity due to recent ideological shifts, various publishers in Iran have continued to republish his writings, including this piece in both digital and print formats. For the purpose of making this new translation, I compared some of them but found no major differences, apart from a few typographical errors and minor variations in paragraphing. Therefore, in terms of content, there is no substantial difference between the published versions. For this translation, I primarily relied on the ([1356 SH] 1977) Persian edition of the book, which, as far as I know, is the oldest version available. To ensure its validity, I also compared this edition with the

version included in Shariati's ([1393 SH] 2014) collected works, *Mazhab Aley-he Mazhab* (Religion against religion).

To the best of my knowledge, this is the first officially published English translation of Ali Shariati's "*Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother!*" A book with a similar title, published a few decades ago, appears in online searches but is unavailable for purchase or download. To verify whether that piece had been previously translated – and, if so, to compare that version with my translation – I attempted to locate that translation. It appears to have been done by Nader Assef and published by the Shariati Foundation in Tehran in 1979 (Shariati [1925SH] 1979), with later republication and distribution in the USA by Kazi Publishing, Inc. Following further inquiry and consultations with some senior Shariati scholars and Iranian librarians, I came across an intriguing narrative that, whether accurate or not, is worth noting. During the revolutionary era from the 1970s to the early 2000s, many of Shariati's works were independently translated into English and other European languages. These translations were often incomplete, inaccurate, riddled with grammatical errors, and unofficially published in limited numbers, typically distributed as pamphlets in Islamic centres across Europe and North America – and I suspect that Assef's translation may belong to this category. Most of these translations focused on his Islamic lectures and were primarily intended to introduce Shariati's ideas to non-Muslim audiences while promoting Islam – particularly revolutionary and ideological Islam. These unofficial translations significantly contributed to the widespread (mis)perception of Shariati as an Islamic ideologue, or, more controversially, as an Islamic Marxist, neither of which is true.

## *Indeed, This Is How It Was, Brother!*[4]

For tonight's talk, I had prepared some notes to conclude what I have shared with you over these past few nights, but the words of my dear brother Parviz Khorsand – who, if not the only one, is undoubtedly the most gifted and powerful writer who has put today's prose in the service of our yesterday's faith – diverted me entirely from what I intended to say. His talk deeply moved me, altering my feelings and redirecting my thoughts. Inspired by him, I feel compelled to share a memory I had previously recounted to him.[5]

If I am sharing [a story] about myself here, it is to recount a "memory", one that is deeply connected to my identity as a member of a class, a society, a city, and a history. On one hand, I belong to the educated class of today, which in this context carries a certain meaning, and adheres to a specific world view – maintains a particular relationship with religion, pursues certain goals, and possesses its own language and culture. On the other hand, I have arisen from a barren landscape, a desert, devoid of prosperity, happiness, or comfort – only dryness, poverty, and life's struggles. Additionally, I belong to a class and lineage whose honour lies in the fact that no noble blood – from those whose nobility is forged by sword and gold – flows in my veins. I sense that my ancestors, my mothers and fathers, always born into poverty, hardship, and deprivation, are fading back into history – and how swiftly they vanish, kept alive solely in our memories, while "history" stands as the enemy of our lineage.

With all these characteristics, my central educational focus – my teaching, research, and reflections – has always centred on "[the question of] civilization". I have consistently viewed civilizations (and the great achievements of human civilization) as humanity's

greatest pride. Wherever I travelled – be it in any city or country – I would make it a priority to visit one of the great works of past civilizations to observe, understand, and appreciate what these people had created and the masterpieces their history had brought into being.

When I was in Greece and visited the magnificent buildings of the Temple of Delphi, filled with beauty and wonder, I was overwhelmed with excitement. Across Europe, Asia, and Africa, I sought out magnificent artefacts that exemplify the power, industry, wealth, art, and genius of nations – each narrating the story of humanity's progress and civilizational triumphs. To me, every artefact was a priceless treasure, a testament to humanity's enduring legacy on earth, showcasing the glorious achievements of generations across the vast expanse of history. This legacy can be observed in Rome, the world's living museum of art and architecture, the land of grand and magnificent temples, and the vast palaces; or in the Far East – China, Cambodia, Vietnam – where the towering mountains were meticulously carved by human hands, fingers, eyes, and nerves into temples devoted to the gods and their earthly representatives – the official clergy of religions.

To me, these were the greatest and most precious heritage of humanity. They were the most cherished sights, filling my eyes and heart with light and joy, overwhelming me with wonder and excitement simply by being in their presence.

Until this summer, during my trip to Africa, where my greatest excitement was to visit the three pyramids of Egypt, all my emotional attachments [to what is called "history"] suddenly shattered in my heart. All those magnificent images I once revered collapsed within me. The fantasies I had cherished evaporated from my mind. I cast my belief in what is deemed "civilization" into the Nile, wiping away thousands of years of illusion in the winds of Egypt!

In August of this year, upon arriving in Egypt, I eagerly rushed to visit the astonishing monuments – the pyramids, one of the Seven Wonders of the World – filled with joy at having accomplished such a dream. I followed the guide, listening intently as he explained the structure of the pyramids, their history, their marvels, their beauty, and their mysteries and secrets! He showed me the masterpieces and recounted the story of 5000 years ago, when "slaves" brought 800 million massive stone blocks – each weighing around two tons – from "Aswan" – the same site where the famous Aswan Dam was built – to Cairo, constructing nine pyramids – six small ones and three that are renowned across the world!

Five thousand years ago, they moved 800 million massive stones across a distance of 980 kilometres to Cairo and stacked them to build a structure meant to bury the mummified bodies of the pharaohs and their queens underneath! The burial chamber of each pyramid – the main room of the tomb – is a large space made up of just six solid, raw stone pieces: four massive stones forming the four walls and two others serving as the floor and ceiling. To imagine the size and weight of the stone that forms the ceiling, it is enough to know that it is made of a single piece of limestone capable of holding several million two-ton stones stacked above it, all the way to the top of the pyramid. Remarkably, this ceiling has been bearing that immense weight for 5000 years.

I was utterly astonished by such a magnificent masterpiece and all its intricate details. Suddenly, I noticed a pile of stones scattered about 400 to 500 metres away. Curious, I asked the guide: "What are those?" With indifference, he replied: "Oh, it's nothing, just a bunch of stones." I insisted: "These are also stones stacked on top of each other; I want

to know what they are." He hesitated, seeming reluctant to give me a proper answer. It felt as though he wanted to brush me off, hoping I wouldn't insist on going there. It was a hot day, and the ground was rocky and rough; it was evident that no one was eager to visit that spot.

Experience has taught me to search for "the lost" and "the accused" in every corner – in books, people, verses, narratives, artefacts, and especially within society and history – because I often discover greater value in what is overlooked. The valuable things are often either "concealed" or, when they can't be hidden, are "discredited". I turned away from the pyramids and their so-called "scientific" explanations, endlessly repeated in books and magazines, and asked, instead: "What is that place?" The guide replied: "Those are catacombs, burial chambers, like tunnels, dug several kilometers deep into the earth." I asked: "Why?" He replied: "They are the graves of the slaves who built these pyramids". For an average of 130 years, 1000 slaves dragged those massive stones from a distance of 1000 kilometres, with many perishing under the immense weight of the stones. Yet, the system of slavery – as Schwartz puts it – prevented the invention of even the most basic tools such as the lever and wheel. The availability of cheap slave labour rendered innovation unnecessary, as slaves were cheaper than animals. Without the slightest compassion, the crushed bodies of the slaves were thrown into pits, and new slaves were immediately assigned to haul the stones.

Every day, news of hundreds of deaths was reported to the pharaoh [each attributed to a different cause]. When new groups of men from Black Africa – who had not yet adapted to Egypt's climate and such brutal working conditions – were brought in, the daily death toll would rise dramatically. The mortality rate also fluctuated with the changing seasons. Outbreaks of infectious diseases such as cholera and plague could transform the death toll into what can only be described as a large-scale massacre. Several other factors contributed to this, including changes in pharaohs' health – often marked by mysterious illnesses and unusual states – which played a role, as did shifts in their personalities. The actions of employers, officials, and overseers – who relentlessly experimented with new methods to extract more labour from the slaves, often indulging in cruel and innovative techniques – had also a direct and devastating impact on the mortality rate.

The pharaoh, deeply religious and firmly believing in the survival of the soul and life after death, ordered that they be buried close to his tomb so that, just as they had been his guardians in life and had served him, they would continue to guard him in death and keep their spirits in the service of his pyramid!

[Haunted by all these images] I cried out: "Leave me alone; I can no longer endure your presence or the sight of these damn pyramids. I'll go by myself." With that, I turned and walked away.

The path from the pharaohs' pyramids to the slaves' burial chambers was anything but easy; it was a jagged, rocky terrain that made passing through it extremely difficult, cutting into the feet of travellers and leaving a trail of blood in their wake! The distance was only a few steps, but those few steps spanned the vast divide between executioner to martyr![6] I sat by the burial chambers and was overwhelmed by a sudden and profound sense of kinship with the sleepers within the chambers. A strong sense of hatred for the pyramids swelled within me! I felt as though I were at the graves of my own family, as though I had known each of them, had been friends with them, had shared life with them. I truly felt like a member of this oppressed family.

It is true that I come from one land and they from another; I belong to one race and they to another. Yet, these are nothing but vile divisions – artificial barriers meant to fragment humanity, separating us from one another, turning relatives into strangers and strangers into relatives. Beyond these barriers, I am of their lineage and race, their true relative, their fellow sufferer. And once again, as I gazed upon the colossal pyramids, I felt an overwhelming sense of alienation from their grandeur, glory, and splendour. Or rather, how much resentment I harboured towards that greatness, art, and civilization – for all the monumental works that civilizations have built throughout history have been erected upon the bones of my ancestors.

The Great Wall of China and all other walls, towers, palaces, buildings, and the great works of human civilization were built in the same way – stone by stone, laid upon the flesh and blood of my ancestors. In that moment, I saw it with my own eyes that civilization means nothing but insult, hatred, animosity, torture and whips, exploitation, bloodshed, execution, martyrdom, corruption, lust, selfishness, enslavement, and … ultimately, a multilayered edifice of oppression that has weighed down on the shoulders of my sisters and brothers for thousands of years. I sat among the piles of stones and felt as if all those who sleep in these burial chambers were speaking to me, teaching me – me, a graduate of humanities from a European university and a professor of the history of civilization at an Iranian university – the first page of the humanities textbook, the first lesson in [the discipline of] history. They were defining civilization for me.

My brothers taught me that everything I was taught in the name of ethics, civilization, and history was a lie. What is written in books and taught in classrooms is merely the legacy of Pharaohs, Qaruns,[7] and Bal'ams.[8] The true history lies in the distance from the pyramids to here, [reminding me that] civilization, ethics, religion, and all the humanities are not found in schools or temples; rather, they are buried just a few steps away, beneath these stones, next to my brothers.

These three pyramids – which, in my eyes, represent the sinister trinity of *Estebdad, Estesmar*, and *Estehmar*[9] – stand as a lasting testament to humanity's pain and suffering, a catastrophic fate imposed upon humankind throughout history. They still stand tall – intact, meticulously maintained, and continually revered. In contrast, these piles of stones – collapsed, shattered, forgotten, and abandoned – embody an alternative reality, affirming the truthfulness of the lesson I discovered here, at my true university, taught by my true teachers – my brothers.

I thank you, my brothers – my buried brothers! You opened my eyes. You revealed to me that everything I learned in the name of religion, ethics, art, history, and civilization – from philosophers, clergy, professors, historians, and scholars of civilization and the humanities – proved to be nothing but the creation of these three pyramids. It was invented solely to serve the pharaoh, his priests, and his sorcerers! I bury all this "knowledge" here beneath these pyramids and begin anew. From here, I will go straight to the land of war, where I will stand against these three devils – what am I saying? – these three faces of the devil [i.e., the sinister trinity of *Estebdad, Estesmar*, and *Estehmar*]. For we are all – my brothers! – victims of these three masters who teach us history and civilization, ethics and religion, while these same three have buried history, civilization, ethics, and religion countless times beneath these hard stones.

I returned to the city, cutting short my stroll through the streets, for I could not focus on anything but the image of that sacred pile of stones etched upon my mind. I could

think of nothing but the lesson I had learned there, which had ignited my entire being and set my soul on fire. I hurried back to my room, sat down, and felt the pounding ache in my head as the familiar faces of my brothers appeared before my eyes – faces stretching back 5000 years. For 130 years, an average of 30,000 of my brothers, from Aswan to Cairo, perished each year!

Five thousand years ago? Suddenly, I realized that this is not just a story from 5000 years ago – my brothers have been bound to the whip and the stone ever since, for 5000 years. They are unaware of what has happened in the world since then. Surely, they would want to know.

Then, I picked up a piece of paper and wrote a letter to one of those hundreds of thousands buried in that chamber, reporting what has happened to us over the past 5000 years; 5000 years in which he has not existed, but slavery and the enslaved – through various forms – have persisted.

I returned to my residential place and wrote a letter to a brother from the countless group of slaves, detailing what has transpired over the past 5000 years, a span during which he has not existed, but slavery and the enslaved have been present in various forms.

I sat down and wrote to him [this letter]:[10]

> Brother,
>
> You left us, and we humans continued to work on building great civilizations, achieving notable conquests, and creating grand honours. They [the conquerors] came to our villages and towns, captured us like livestock, and forced us to work on constructing their tombs. If we could no longer endure the labour, they would cast our bodies into the construction, treating us as a piece of stone, and if somehow we managed to complete the task, the glory, grandeur, and honour of the construction would be credited to someone who had done nothing but issue commands – commands backed by force, uttered in a few firm words that didn't even form a sentence. The only activity recorded in history is the command that initiated this action, leaving no trace of us – not even a name in a memory.
>
> Sometimes they took us to war, to fight against people we had never met and we didn't know, to wield swords against those we held no grudge against – even against those who were our comrades, those of our class, those who shared our fate.
>
> They took us away [to wars], leaving our old and broken mothers and fathers awaiting us – their longing never fulfilled.
>
> "These wars", as a scholar once said,[11] "were battles between two groups who fought each other without knowing one another, for the benefit of those who did not fight but knew each other." We were taken away, annihilated, slaughtered, and massacred; if we were defeated, the grief and pain fell upon our fathers and mothers, and upon our abandoned villages and our ruined fields; and if we were victorious, the honour and power went to others. We were left with neither glory nor spoils.
>
> Brother! After you, a great transformation took place. The pharaohs, the powerful, and tyrannical rulers of history, changed their view about life, and we rejoiced at this shift. They had long believed that their spirits were eternal, always moving or hovering around their graves, and that if the body remained intact, the spirit would maintain its connection to the body. It was this belief that compelled them to force us – and you – to build this massive and murderous structure over their graves. But then, they became enlightened. They abandoned their obsession with death and let go of those outdated beliefs. For us, this was incredible

news: freedom from building those tombs, from hauling 800 million stones across 1000 kilometres, and from stacking them one atop the other . .

But, brother! Our joy was fleeting and fragile. For after you left, they returned, storming our villages and forcing us back into servitude and slavery. We once more carried the massive stones and pillars on our backs and shoulders, but this time, not for their graves – they no longer cared for their tombs – instead, it was for their palaces and grand castles. These towering structures rose upon the earth, built with our blood and flesh; and once again, beside them, lay the vast burial chambers of our ancestors.

Brother! Once again, in the abyss of despair, hope called out to us. Great prophets emerged: Zoroaster the Great, Mani the Great, Buddha the Great, Confucius the Wise, Laozi the Profound .. .A window had opened, and a glimmer of salvation had appeared. The gods sent forth their prophets to rescue us from humiliation and slavery, replacing oppression and servitude with faith and worship.

But brother! These divine messengers descended from their sacred realms – the houses of their mission – likewise showed no concern for us, nor did they mention our name or memory. Instead they headed to palaces and courts.

Confucius, the wise one, who spoke extensively of society and humanity – whom we deeply trusted – went to serve the Ministry of "Lu" and become the companion to the princes of China. And Buddha, who was himself the great prince of Benares, distanced himself from all of us, and, through solitude, embraced great austerities and crafted thoughtful ideas, all to reach "Nirvana" – wherever that may be.

And [similarly], Zarathustra – a prophet who arose in Azerbaijan – did not address us, the scourged ones and the mourners of the burial chambers – chambers that hold the graves of thousands of our enslaved brothers. Instead, he hastened to Balkh, the court of King Vishtaspa, seeking his protection at the cost of severing his ties with us.

And Mani brought to us [the notion of] light [offered us a light-centred philosophy], and waged a relentless war against darkness. By whispering the promise of enlightening our souls, he ignited a spark of hope within us, the prisoners in the darkness of oppression.[12] We thought he was the one calling for our liberation, our salvation. But he wrapped his enlightening insights in a book and presented it to Shapur of the Sasanian dynasty. Later, he delivered a sermon at Shapur's coronation and took it as a great honour to accompany him on his travels through Sri Lanka, India, and Balkh. All of this might have been overlooked, until he betrayed us, crushed us by reciting a verse upon our defeat: "The defeated belong to the realm of darkness, and the victorious to the realm of light!" And is it not true that we, the defeated, have always been so throughout the course of history?

Brother! You were a victim of those grand edifices built over tombs, and I am a victim of these great palaces.

And suddenly I saw that alongside the pharaohs and Qaruns – who brought us into servitude and forced us into labour – others also emerged in the name of the successors of these prophets: the official clergy. From Palestine to Iran, to Egypt, to China, to wherever there is a society and civilization, we had to haul stones to build temples beside these pyramids and grand palaces.

The representatives of god and the heirs of the prophets shackled us anew. They bound us with new chains, plundering from us under the name of zakat[13] and sending us to other battlefields in the name of *jihad*[14] all under the pretence of defending a religion. The demands grew relentless, until we were left with no choice but to offer our children as sacrifices at the altars of temples, before the idols.

Brother, you must know that all the temples are drenched, soaked with the blood of our innocent children. For thousands of years – more miserable than you and your fate – we kept building graves, palaces, and temples, while the gods and their representatives, alongside the pharaohs and Qaruns, turned against us!

Three-fifths of all the lands of Iran were taken from us by the representatives of the god, the priests of Ahura [the Persian god]! We were their peasants, their slaves, their servants – merely working for them. Four-fifths of all the lands of the Franks were seized from us by the priests. We toiled – had constructed temples, had built the vast empire of Rome and the grand temples of China – and we died.

Along with the powerful pharaohs and the wealthy Qaruns, victory belonged also to the priests, clergymen, and leaders of various religions. And I, living thousands of years after you and having witnessed the death of all my kin and brothers, came to feel that even the gods harbour hatred towards the slaves, and that religion is yet another chain bondage for us. The priests, clergymen, and religious leaders are nothing but the instruments to uphold this system [of power and oppression] – sustaining its logic and strengthening the foundations of these palaces and tombs.

And then, following the wise men and great philosophers – those who think and understand far more than us, men like Aristotle – who say that in this world some are born to be slaves and others to be masters, I attained this certainty that we were born for servitude, and this is our inevitable fate. Our predestined fate is to carry burdens on our shoulders, endure oppression, suffer lashes, face humiliation, be deemed impure, live as slaves, and nothing more.

But brother! Suddenly, once more, I heard news that a man had descended from the mountain, and cried out next to a temple: "I am a messenger of God."

And I trembled again, fearing it to be yet another deception paving the way for a new oppression. But when he opened his mouth to speak, I could not believe: "I have come from God, for God has willed to bestow grace upon all the slaves and wretched of the earth, making them the leaders of the world and heirs of the earth."[15]

How strange! How could God address the slaves and wretched, promising them salvation, leadership, and inheritance of the earth? It seemed impossible to believe! I thought to myself: He is just like the other prophets – those from Iran, China, and India – a prince who has been called to prophethood to ally with power and forge a new dominion.

They said: "No, he was an orphan, and everyone knows that he spent his life tending sheep behind this very mountain." I exclaimed: "How strange! How could God choose His messenger from among shepherds?"

They replied: "He is the final successor in a lineage of shepherds, all of whom were both messengers and shepherds." I trembled – out of excitement, or perhaps an inexplicable fear – realizing that, for the first time, a prophet had risen from among us.

I believed in him because I saw all my brothers gathered around him, standing by his side: Bilal – born into slavery, the son of enslaved parents, an outsider from Abyssinia;[16] Salman – a homeless man once enslaved in Persia; Abu Dharr – a poor and unknown wretched and downtrodden man from the desert; and Salim – the former slave of Hudhayfah's wife, once dismissed as an insignificant, low-priced Black slave, yet who rose to become the leader of all of his [the Prophet's] companions.

I trusted him, believed his words, and admitted to [the righteousness of] his faith because his palace was nothing more than a few humble clay rooms – rooms he had built with his own

hands, mixing mud and carrying dirt – and his throne was merely a piece of wood covered with a layer of palm leaves.

This was all he had, and that was all the burden he ever placed on the shoulders of the people – to build his house! That is how he lived, and that [was] where he died. I came from Iran, from the system of the priestly lineage that always dragged us into slavery for their wars and for their power. I fled to his city, living among the slaves, refugees, homeless, and wretched of the world, until death weighed down his eyelids, and drew a curtain over our sun.

And brother! Suddenly, I saw that once again the grand and glorious temples rising in his name, and swords – inscribed with verses of *jihad* – hanging over us. Once again, the treasury was filled with the spoils of our plunder. The representatives of this man descended upon our villages, enslaving our youth for the service of their leaders [the so-called representatives of that man] and the chiefs of their tribes, selling our mothers in distant markets, and killing our men in the name of *jihad* for God. They plundered all that we had in the name of zakat.

I lost my faith again! I became hopeless about what I could do, brother!?

A [new source of] power has emerged once again, this time cloaked in the guise of monotheism. It carried the same [ancient] idols and, in the same way, kindled the flames of deception in the temple and altar [but all in the name] of "Allah". The same faces of Qarun and Pharaoh – faces you know well, brother – and the faces of false saints – partners and conspirators with Qarun and Pharaoh – struck us with the whip of sharia[17] in the name of the caliphate of Allah and the caliphate of the Messenger of Allah. And once again, we fell into servitude to build the great mosque of Damascus.

Once more, the great wars, the magnificent altars, the grand palaces, the Green Palace of Damascus, and the House of Caliphate of *The One Thousand and One Nights* in Baghdad rose at the cost of our blood and lives – this time all in the name of "Allah".

We eventually came to believe that there was no way out – no path to salvation – only a doomed fate of slavery, condemned to be victims. Who was that man? Did he hide all this in his message? Did he really deceive us? Or is it that, in this system – where we now banished to its dungeons, and all our brothers, our lands, our very existence, and our hope for the future have been plundered and destroyed – he, the Prophet, is also a victim, just like us?

I no longer knew a way forward. What could I possibly do? Where was I supposed to go, and on whom could I rely? To the priests? How could I return to the temples that had always been complicit in deception and allied with those in power? To the leaders and the so-called nationalist claimants of freedom [after the Arab conquest of Iran]? They were not saviours, nor freedom fighters, but merely those who had lost their hereditary power in Khorasan, Sistan, and Gorgan under the new regime, now waging their battles to reclaim ancestral rule and revive their pre-Islamic systems of ignorance. To the mosques? What difference was there between these mosques and those temples?

Brother! Suddenly, I saw reality unfolding before my eyes: swords engraved with verses of *jihad*, temples[18] resounding [with] echoes of hymns and prayers of "Allah", the muezzins tirelessly proclaiming the call to *Tawhid*,[19] and the sacred faces who, under the banners of caliphate and imamate, claimed to uphold the tradition of that prophet – yet, in one way or another, all of them were enslaving us and subjecting us to massacre. Yet, before these swords and altars could make me their victim, they had already claimed a far greater one: "Ali"!

Brother! Ali, the close kin of the Prophet himself, was killed on the altar dedicated to worshipping "Allah". He and his family were oppressed long before me, before my family, and before the families of the downtrodden and oppressed across history, and his house was plundered in the name of the sacred traditions – *jihad* and zakat – long before ours. And the Quran – before it was turned into a weapon for exploitation, oppression, and enslavement – was hoisted onto a spear, and with it, they defeated Ali.[20]

How astonishing! After 5000 years, I finally found a man who spoke of God – not for the masters or those in power, but for the slaves. He prayed, not like Buddha to reach "Nirvana", nor like monks to deceive people, nor like ascetics to reach God, but a prayer at the mosque of "Allah" in hopes of the liberation of the "masses".

I found a man, a man of *jihad*, a man of justice – a justice so harsh and unforgiving that its first victim was his own brother. A man whose wife – who was both his wife and the daughter of that great prophet – laboured, suffered, and tasted deprivation and hunger like us with her flesh and soul, just as my sister did, just as we do.

Brother! I found a man whose daughter and son inherited the red flag [of resistance] that has been in our hands throughout history. Now, after 5000 years, out of fear of those temples you know and I know, out of fear of those grand edifices for which you were sacrificed and I was, and out of fear of those terrifying powers you know and I know, I have taken refuge beside this clay house, deserted and silent. The companions of the Prophet have moved away from the house, and he is alone; his wife has succumbed to death, and he himself speaks of all my and your pains and sufferings with his God in the palm groves of Banu Najjar. Out of fear of those dreadful temples, the terrifying palaces, and the treasures that were all amassed with our blood and suffering, I take refuge in this house, resting my head against its deserted door and weeping for the sorrows of centuries.

Brother! He and all those who remained loyal to him were of our lineage, the oppressed. For the first time, he used poetry and the beauty of words not to justify our deprivation and the empowerment of the powerful, but for our liberation and awakening. He speaks better than Demosthenes, but not to claim his rights. He speaks better than the eloquent Bossuet, but not at the court of Louis; instead, he cries out before the oppressed against the powerful. He unsheathes his sword not to defend himself, his family, his lineage, or his nation, nor to defend the great powers, but better than Spartacus and more sincerely, to save us in every struggle.

He thinks better than Socrates, but not to prove the virtues of the aristocracy from which the slaves are excluded, but to affirm the human values that reside within us. For he is not the heir of Qaruns, pharaohs, or priests. He has neither a *mihrab*[21] nor a mosque; he is the sacrifice of the *mihrab*.[22]

He is the embodiment of justice and the embodiment of thought, but not in the corners of libraries, schools, and academia, nor among the clean and esteemed scholars sitting next to luxury shelves of books – who, due to their profound thoughts, are oblivious to the fate of the people and the suffering of the masses and the hunger of the common folk. While he soars at the heights of the heavens [in his prophetic experience of ascension], the wails of an orphan child pull him down, wake him up, turn the world into a hell for him, and ignite his entire being.

While praying, at the very moment that he forgets the pain of his body and the sting of the dagger, he cries out against the injustice done to a Jewish woman, saying: "If someone dies of this shame, they are not to be blamed."

He is, brother, a man of poetry and the beauty of words, but not like *The Shahnameh*, which in its 60,000 verses mentions our lineage and a brother of ours – Kaveh – only once. He was

a blacksmith obviously from our lineage, our bloodline, who committed himself to freedom, revolution and the salvation of the people and nation, yet he remains overlooked. This lone hero of our lineage, who made it into *The Shahnameh*, disappears before he could truly rise. Where? Why? Because the [privileged] lineage and [aristocratic] race of Fereydun have overshadowed him, which is why *The Shahnameh* features Kaveh in no more than a few verses.

Now, brother! I live in a time, a society, and a situation where my kin, my class, and I are once again in need of him.

Unlike other philosophers, unlike other intellectuals and thinkers – who, if they are intellectuals, are not men of action; and if they are men of action, are not men of thought and understanding; and if they are both, are not men of swords and *jihad*; and if they are all three, are not men of piety and purity; and if they are all four, are not men of love, feeling, and spiritual delicacy; and if they embody all of these, they do not know God and do not lose themselves in their faith, remaining instead confined within the limits of their own selves – he is a man in every dimension of humanity: working like a labourer – like you and me – using the same hands that inscribe great divine lines on paper to dig wells, build aqueducts, and bring forth water in the salt desert surrounding the city.

Just like a labourer, but not in service to others or to himself; while being in the middle of the aqueduct, he suddenly cries out: "Pull me up." And when they bring him out of the aqueduct, while his head and face are covered in mud, and water bursts forth, creating a stream in that burning desert around the city. The Banu Hashim rejoice, but he, without taking a breath, looks back and says: "Good news to my heirs who will receive not a drop of this water." It is for you and me that he has dedicated himself, not himself and his tribe [Banu Hashim], brother!

And now we are in need of him and in need of a leader like him, as all civilizations, cultures, and religions have either turned humans into economic animals or into inwardly worshipping animals in the caves of devotion and spirituality; or into one-dimensional beings: into thinkers and intellectuals, but without feeling, without heart, without depth, and without love; or into men of feeling and love and inspiration, but without reason, without thought, without knowledge, and without logic. He is the man of all these dimensions: the divine essence of toil and suffering, the divine essence of speech, the divine essence of *jihad*, the divine essence of sincerity, the divine essence of loyalty, the divine essence of pain, the divine essence of silence, the divine essence of shouting, the divine essence of justice.

And now, brother! I find myself in a society where an enemy stands before me, a powerful system that rules over more than half the world – indeed, the entire world – and is shaping my generation for new slavery from within – an internalized one!

Now, it seems we do not labour for anyone; we are free, and the era of slavery has ended. Yet, we are trapped in a bondage worse than your own era. Our thoughts are enslaved, our hearts are confined, and our will has been surrendered, and we have been nurtured in a freedom-flavoured servitude. With the power of science, sociology, culture, art, and in the name of sexual freedoms, consumerism, hedonism, and individualism, they have completely erased our faith in purpose and human responsibility, and our belief in his teachings from our hearts and minds.

And now, brother! We have become like empty beautiful jars, powerless before these ruling systems, consuming everything they produce – in the name of sect, in the name of blood, in the name of soil, and in the name of him but against him, we are being torn apart, so that each piece may be an easy morsel for their mouths. Division! Separation!

His followers have torn apart his legacy, setting it against one another. This legacy has now turned upon itself, turning his followers into one another's enemies. Why, in such a condition that governs the world and us, do they turn against each other? Why should they harbour hatred simply because one prays with his hands bound while the other prays with open hands? Why should they become enemies just because one prays on the carpet without a *turbah*,[23] while the other places their forehead on a *turbah*?

They have intensified wars, hostilities, and conflicts to this extent, forcing our intellectuals to seek refuge in other lands, while they have taken on the guise of shepherds.[24]

Brother! You could easily recognize your master by the sting of the whip on your body, understanding that you were a slave, knowing why you were enslaved, when it happened, and who was responsible. Yet now, facing a fate similar to yours, we do not even know who has dragged us into the slavery of this century, from where we are being plundered, or how we have fallen into submission, distorted thought, and earthly servitudes.

Now they not only enslave us like beasts but have also subjected us to relentless exploitation. We have been exploited after your era and even more than your generation. All these powers, capitals, systems, machines, grand palaces of the world, and all this immense and rich wealth and production are fuelled by our flesh, blood, suffering, and deprivation – while our share being merely what is needed to keep us working tomorrow. We are more deprived than in your era, and the oppression, class discrimination, and tyranny are more pronounced than in your time, yet they carry a new face and even newer adornments!

And brother! Ali[25] spent his entire life on these three words.

The embodiment of 23 years of effort, sacrifice, and *jihad* to establish a faith among the savages scattered across Arabia [during the period of Muhammad as the Prophet]; followed by 25 years of silence and endurance to preserve the unity of the Muslim people against the Roman and Persian empires [during the rule of the first three caliphs]; and also five years of relentless effort and suffering to establish justice, to confront all our grievances and frustrations with his sword, and to liberate us [during his role as the fourth caliph].

He could not [save us]! He could not [accomplish his ideals]! Yet, he succeeded in proclaiming a religion, a leadership, and a mission that would endure forever – for me, for us, brother – the religion of justice and the leadership of the people; and he left behind three slogans for which he sacrificed his entire being and his family: *Maktab, Vahdat, Edalat*.[26]

## Notes

1. Meaning "religious ordinance".
2. One of the finest examples of this epistolary form of writing is *Gulshan-e Raz* (The rose garden of secrets), written by Sheikh Mahmoud Shabestari, a prominent 14th-century Persian Islamic mystic and poet.
3. Hamid Dabashi (2016, 271–272) offers a nuanced take on this issue, suggesting that the perception of Arabic as inherently sacred – due to its status as the language of the Quran – creates a constraint that limits the possibility of alternative forms of expression.
4. All footnotes are the translator's unless specifically attributed to the author.
5. It was customary for the speaker to begin with a brief introductory note, intended to prepare the audience and contextualize it for that specific setting.
6. The word "*Shahid*" in Persian, often translated as martyr, literally means "the one who witnesses" – that is, "witnessing us and our condition while awaiting our response".

7. Reference to Qarun b. Yaṣhura. In Persian Islamic literature, Qarun symbolizes the corruption of wealth and power; a magnate undone by arrogance and avarice.
8. Reference to Bal'am b. Beor. In Persian Islamic literature, Bal'am symbolizes the corruption of religion and learning; a "scholar" who exploits his knowledge to serve worldly and material interests.
9. *Estebdad* (tyranny and oppression), *Estesmar* (exploitation and enslavement), and *Estehmar* (indoctrination and manipulation) constitute the triad through which Shariati theorizes domination in history. "*Estehmār*", literally "to turn someone into a donkey", is his neologism for the deliberate stupefaction, indoctrination, and manipulation of the public.
10. "As the original letter is missing, I recount it from memory rather than from the page. Surely, it would have been better to have the exact original" (author's footnote).
11. "Note that this statement is treated as explaining/justifying the whole of history" (author's footnote).
12. In Persian, the words for "darkness" (*Zolmat*) and "oppression" (*Zolm*) are all from the same root.
13. Serving the gods by offering your valuable belongings to temples.
14. Literally meaning "action" and "struggle", the term in Islamic discourse encompasses both personal-existential and social-political dimensions, referring both to the inner moral and spiritual effort to live righteously and the outward efforts to uphold and defend the community.
15. This sentence is not a direct quotation from the Quran. Rather, Shariati weaves together phrases drawn from different verses. For closely related verses, see the Quran, 28:5–6 and 3:49.
16. The name by which present-day Ethiopia was known until the mid-20th century.
17. "Religious law".
18. "Mosques".
19. "The oneness of God".
20. A reference to the Battle of Siffin (37 AH; 657 CE).
21. "*Mihrad*" is a niche or recessed arch in the wall of a mosque that indicates the qiblah – the direction of Mecca towards which Muslims face during prayer. It often features ornate decoration and marks the spot where the prayer leader (imam) stands.
22. A reference to the assassination of Ali while he was praying in the mosque.
23. "*Turbah*" is a small clay tablet, often from soil of a holy site such as Karbala, that Shia Muslims place their forehead on during prostration in prayer.
24. "a role similar to those of prophets of the Abrahamic religions."
25. The narrative so far implies that "Ali" refers to the first Shi'i Imam. However, the author may be playfully alluding to himself, as he also shares the name "Ali".
26. These correspond, respectively, to faith, solidarity, and justice.

## Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

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